EXTENDED TIME WITH THE FATHER

In a marriage, it is important to prioritize healthy rhythms in the midst of the busyness of life. These often include a daily touch point, a weekly date night, and a monthly/quarterly extended time together.

So in our union with Christ, it is important to develop healthy rhythms in the midst of the noise around us to hear from our savior. In addition to daily time with God, a helpful rhythm is an extended time away together.

And he said to them, "Come away by yourselves to a desolate place and rest a while." For many were coming and going, and they had no leisure even to eat.
Mark 6:31

Consider the verse above. To what were the disciples invited into? What were they invited away from?

WHAT is an extended time with the Father

There is no right way to have an extended time away with the Father, nor set amount of time required. For some this may mean stretching yourself to spend two hours with God. For others it might look like a morning, an entire day, or a weekend.

Lorne Sanny, former president of The Navigators, once said:
"The result of your day in prayer should be answers to the two questions Paul asked the Lord on the Damascus road (Acts 22:6-10). Paul's first question was, 'Who are you, Lord?' The Lord replied, 'I am Jesus.' You will be seeking to know Him, to find out who He is. The second question Paul asked was, 'What shall I do, Lord?' and the Lord answered him specifically. This should be answered or reconfirmed for you in that part of the day when you unhurriedly seek His will for you."

HOW to spend an extended time with the Father

Pastor and teacher John Mark Comer once remarked that our lives can feel like water in a pitcher, sloshing around when moved. Once the pitcher is placed steady on a table it will take the water some time to settle. This is often true of our lives in an ever more hurried culture.

Begin your time settling your heart. This may involve going for a walk, journaling, praying (silently, out loud as you walk, or with a friend), singing hymns or reflecting on a Psalm. The goal of this time is to answer the question: How am I doing?

After some time, it will likely be helpful to go to Scripture. Consider reading through an entire epistle, a section of scripture, or reviewing verses you have found meaningful. Prayerfully consider who the Lord is and what He might have to say to you through the time.

EXTENDED TIME WITH THE FATHER

Everyone is different. Some may prefer a plan, others prefer the freedom to approach the Word unhurried. Some may like to sing or reflect who God is through nature, others may want to spend time studying in-depth a passage of scripture. Whatever the case, keep the focus of the time on knowing God and hearing from Him.

Use the QR code if you're looking for a framework to use.

BEST PRACTICES for spending extended time with the Father.

- **TIMING:** This time never simply "appears" - it must be intentionally created and rigorously guarded. Consider scheduling this with a like-minded friend so you both can stay accountable.

- **RHYTHMS:** While this practice may be particularly helpful when facing an important decision, it is helpful to develop this discipline as a regular rhythm in our lives! Consider blocking out time weekly or monthly. Many have found it helpful to spend a weekend away with the Lord annually. Consider fasting during this time to remember how the Lord sustains you!

- **DISTRACTIONS:** It is only natural for distractions to arise! Keep a piece of paper close by to write down any tasks that come to mind that you might need to attend to later. Resist the temptation to work on something that comes up. Write it down and move on, knowing you can address it later. Consider silencing or even turning off your phone and electronics for this time.

- **WHAT TO TAKE:** Consider bringing noise canceling headphones, a pen and your journal, your Bible, any sermon or workshop notes you would like to review, verses you have been memorizing or meditating on, and possibly a devotional book. It may be helpful to bring old journals to review during this time.

- **STAY ALERT:** Be sure to get a good night sleep before setting out on this time. If spending all day or multiple days with the Lord, take breaks every so often to go for a walk, or go somewhere you can talk out loud. Give variety in what you do -- pray, journal, spend time in Scripture, etc.

- **KEEP THE MAIN THING THE MAIN THING:** The purpose of a date with a loved one is not to try out a new restaurant or see the movie you've been wanting to see; it is to spend time together with the someone you love. So it is with the Lord during this time. The primary goal is to spend time with the Father. Enjoy hearing from Him what He longs to say to you!

He says, "Be still, and know that I am God; I will be exalted among the nations, I will be exalted in the earth."
Psalm 46:10

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